

2027 College Draft Arms Review

Draft classes are often remembered for a single defining characteristic. The 2023 MLB Draft will likely be remembered for Paul Skenes establishing himself as the consensus first overall pick before rapidly becoming one of the most dominant pitchers in professional baseball. Other classes are defined less by elite talent at the top and more by the depth throughout the board. The 2021 draft, for example, has already produced 10 big leaguers drafted in its first round, including Cleveland Guardians right-hander Gavin Williams.

The 2027 class of college pitchers has a chance to be remembered for something different: it offers both.

After evaluating 53 draft-eligible college pitchers across Division I baseball along with 217 unique pitches, I came to a conclusion regarding the class that we are about to see. This class combines legitimate top-of-the-draft talent with uncommon depth throughout the middle tiers of the board. There are potential Friday-night aces from Power Four programs, high-octane relievers capable of moving quickly through professional systems, and a large group of starters who already possess multiple professional-quality offerings.

There is velocity. There is swing-and-miss. There are power arms, pitchability arms, and some of the deepest collections of breaking balls and left-handed pitching talent that I have evaluated in a single class. While it remains far too early to project the ultimate legacy of the group, the foundation is already in place for the 2027 college pitching class to become one of the strongest in recent memory.

The Top of the Class Has Stars

There are four pitchers who currently separate themselves from the rest of the class: Sam Cozart, Dax Whitney, Tomas Valincius, and Chris Levonas. While each arrives there in a different way, all four possess the traits typically associated with future professional starters. They combine

high-quality fastballs, multiple above-average secondary pitches, and the ability to generate outs against hitters from both sides of the plate.

Perhaps the most surprising member of the group is Cozart, who spent 2026 serving as Texas' freshman closer rather than working in the rotation. Despite the role, the combination of a dominant fastball, three quality secondaries, and exceptional strike-throwing ability makes projecting him as a professional starter a comfortable decision. Whitney enters 2027 recovering from UCL surgery and will not take the mound this spring, but his combination of velocity, fastball quality, and bat-missing secondaries still places him among the premier talents in the class. Valincius and Levonas are the more traditional headliners. Both already have significant workloads against high-level competition and will enter 2027 as the expected leaders of their respective rotations. Valincius pairs a power sinker with one of the better slider-changeup combinations in the class, while Levonas attacks hitters with a deep five-pitch mix boasting 3 above average off speed pitches and some of the more projectable command among draft-eligible college pitchers.

The common thread connecting all four pitchers is the absence of obvious weakness. Each possesses at least three pitches that project as average-or-better professional offerings, and each has already demonstrated the ability to handle a starter's workload.

The Second and Third Tiers are Deep

Every draft class produces a handful of future professional starters. What separates the 2027 class is the number of pitchers beyond the top tier who still project comfortably in a rotation role.

Different Paths to Starter Projection

What stood out most during the evaluation process was how few of these pitchers arrived at a starter projection in the same way. Aidan King projects because of strike throwing, athleticism, and a deep four-pitch mix. Will Sanford projects because of one of the best fastball-curveball combinations in the class. Dylan Volantis relies on movement diversity, sequencing, and a one-of-one release profile,

while Ryan McPherson succeeds through a complete five-pitch arsenal. Even among pitchers projected as starters, there is very little overlap in how they create outs. At the same time, several current relievers possess starter traits. Easton Hawk and Zachary Strickland spent 2026 working out of UCLA's bullpen, yet both feature dominant fastball-slider pairings and enough arsenal depth to warrant future starter consideration.

Plenty of Depth After the First Round

Perhaps the most encouraging takeaway is that the depth does not disappear after the headline names. Players such as Camden Clark, Cole Gibler, Cooper Williams, Charlie Foster, Noah Franco, and Matthew Shorey all possess at least one pathway toward professional relevance. Not every arm will ultimately remain in a rotation, but many already possess enough pitch quality, athleticism, or arsenal depth to justify continued starter development.

What makes this depth particularly compelling is that it is supported by actual pitch quality rather than projection alone. Across the 53 pitchers evaluated for this project, I assigned 99 future grades of 50 or better, an average of nearly two major league average-or-better pitches per pitcher. Having nearly two per player across an entire class is a testament to the overall strength of the group.

The result is a class where professional organizations will not be limited to evaluating only the top names on the board. There are viable starter candidates throughout the second and third tiers, creating depth that extends well beyond the players currently receiving national attention. Evaluators are not searching for a handful of starter candidates next June, they are looking through dozens.

Off-Speed Pitches Define the Class

The most surprising takeaway from evaluating 53 pitchers was how often the best pitch in a profile wasn't the fastball. From Dylan Volantis' curveball to William Schmidt's slider and Chris Levonas' pair of breaking balls, the 2027 class is driven by an unusual collection of bat-missing off-speed pitches. 34 of the 53 arms highest rated pitches were secondaries and there were 70 individual

off-speed pitches given a 50 or higher grade across 154 individual secondaries. (Note: for purposes of this, cutters are off-speed pitches due to how cutters are used in the modern game of baseball).

The Rise of the Change-up

I assigned 14 future 50-or-better grades to changeups and another five to splitters, highlighting the growing importance of offspeed weapons in modern pitcher development. Tanner Bradley's profile is built around a devastating cambio that generated a 62.5% whiff rate and serves as the centerpiece of his entire arsenal. Noah Wech pairs a quality fastball with a low-spin changeup that consistently produces uncomfortable swing decisions. Wylan Moss throws a change-up that has been described as "UFO-like" with how purely lateral it moves to his arm'side. Ryan McPherson, Camden Clark, and Will Sanford all feature changeups that significantly elevate their starter projections and provide answers against opposite-handed hitters. The ability to throw a quality changeup has become increasingly important as professional organizations continue searching for starters capable of navigating lineups multiple times.

Multiple Paths To Swing-And-Miss

What makes the group especially special is the variety of ways these pitchers create swing-and-miss. Some rely on velocity and power shapes. Others lean on movement, deception, and sequencing. Sam Cozart, Zach Edwards, and Dax Whitney generate whiffs with power breaking balls thrown in the mid-to-upper 80s. Dylan Volantis and Will Sanford do much of their damage with elite vertical breaking balls. Tanner Bradley and Noah Wech rely heavily on changeups. Casan Evans attacks hitters with one of the best splitters in the class. There is no singular blueprint for success. Instead, the class offers an unusually diverse collection of secondary pitches that create outs in dramatically different ways.

Ultimately, the strength of the class is not simply that it throws as hard as ever. The difference in 2027 is the number of pitchers who already possess professional-quality secondary offerings. The

fastballs may get the attention, but the offspeed pitches are what give this class its depth and help explain why so many arms project comfortably into professional rotations.

The Left-Handed Depth is Exceptional

One of the most overlooked strengths of the 2027 class is the sheer number of viable left-handed pitching prospects spread throughout the board. While every draft cycle features a handful of notable southpaws, few offer the combination of depth, diversity, and projection present in this group. The headliners will receive most of the attention, but the strength of the class lies in how many intriguing left-handed arms exist beyond the obvious names. The 15 lefties I covered combined for 25 50+ grades across their 62 individual pitches. This level of arsenal depth extends from the top with Bowie, Volantis, and Valincius but throughout the group.

What stands out most is the variety of profiles. Cole Gibler creates uncomfortable angles through a crossfire delivery while pairing a quality slider with an emerging changeup. Charlie Foster attacks hitters with a four-pitch mix highlighted by a split-change that gives him a legitimate weapon against right-handed hitters. Mason Brassfield brings size, athleticism, and one of the better sliders among left-handed pitchers in the class, while Henry Zatkowski relies on deception, movement diversity, and one of the more unique release profiles in the dataset.

The next tier is equally interesting. Cooper Williams generates ground balls through a heavy sinker-slider combination, Blaine Brown offers mid-90s velocity and multiple breaking ball shapes, and Noah Franco brings a power sinker profile that could eventually fit in a high-leverage professional role. Even pitchers with limited collegiate workloads, such as Mason Russell and Matthew Shorey, possess traits that warrant professional attention and further development.

Perhaps most importantly, these pitchers succeed in different ways. Some rely on velocity. Others create deception through unusual release characteristics. Some attack with sinkers, while others are driven by sliders, sweepers, or changeups. The result is a class that provides professional organizations with a wide range of developmental options rather than a collection of pitchers built from the same template.

The Class Has No Obvious Weakness

Most draft classes can be defined as much by what they lack as by what they possess. Some years feature elite talent at the top of the board but little depth behind it. Others produce a large quantity of professional prospects but lack true frontline arms. Some classes are dominated by relievers, while others struggle to produce quality left-handed pitching or reliable secondary offerings. The 2027 college pitching class largely avoids those concerns.

The class offers frontline talent, middle-tier starter depth, quality left-handed pitching, and one of the strongest collections of secondary offerings in recent memory. The diversity of archetypes is particularly impressive. Teams looking for polished rotation pieces can find them in pitchers such as Aidan King and Ryan McPherson. Organizations that prioritize power stuff can gravitate toward Sam Cozart, Zach Edwards, and Joshua Whritenour. Evaluators who value elite movement characteristics can focus on Dylan Volantis, Tanner Bradley, and Noah Wech. Even bullpen-focused organizations will find a deep collection of high-leverage relief candidates capable of moving quickly through a system.

The strength of the class is also not concentrated within a single conference or geographic region. Impact arms emerge from the SEC, ACC, Big 12, Big Ten, Sun Belt, American Athletic Conference, Ivy League, and several other conferences. The geographic and conference diversity of the class further reinforces the idea that this depth is genuine rather than concentrated. Elite prospects can be found in traditional pitching factories such as LSU, Vanderbilt, Wake Forest, Florida, and Texas, but impactful arms also emerge from programs such as Yale, Iowa, Southern Miss, East Carolina, and Oklahoma State. The SEC may possess the largest collection of top-end talent, but quality pitching is spread throughout the ACC, Big 12, Big Ten, American Athletic Conference, Ivy League, and beyond. Evaluators searching for pitching help will not need to focus on a single conference or region. Rather, the strength of the class is distributed throughout Division I baseball, creating one of the broadest talent pools in recent memory.

This optimism does not mean every pitcher will reach his ceiling. Some starters will ultimately move to relief. Some relievers will fail to make the transition into larger workloads. Others will simply

stall in development. That is true of every draft class. What separates this group is the volume of viable pathways to professional success.

Conclusion and Final Thoughts

As I conclude this review of the 2027 class, it is worth remembering that the 53 Division I pitchers evaluated for this project represent only a fraction of the talent that will ultimately define the draft. Yet even within that sample, the depth of the class became impossible to ignore. Across those evaluations were frontline starter candidates, future high-leverage relievers, elite breaking balls, devastating changeups, unique release profiles, and one of the deepest collections of left-handed pitching talent I have encountered in a single class.

When I began this project, I expected to find a handful of standout arms. Instead, I found a class defined by volume, diversity, and quality. Whether that ultimately translates into major league success remains to be seen, but the foundation is already in place for the 2027 college pitching class to be remembered as one of the strongest groups in recent years.

That volume of talent may ultimately be the defining characteristic of the 2027 college pitching class. The stars are real, but so is the volume of talent behind them. Whether this group eventually produces future All-Stars, Cy Young candidates, or simply a large number of major league contributors remains to be seen. What is already clear, however, is that the foundation for a special pitching class is in place. If the 2023 class becomes remembered for Paul Skenes and the 2021 class becomes remembered for the volume of major league starters it produced, the 2027 class may ultimately be remembered for possessing a rare combination of both traits.